

PIRATE SHIP

On a dark, stormy night in 1717, a pirate ship hit a sandbank and sank to the bottom of the sea, taking with it all its treasure and most of the crew. This unlucky ship was the *Whydah*. The wreck site, off the Atlantic coast of the US, is the first ever proven to be that of a pirate ship.

Changing fates

The *Whydah*, seen here as a model, was an English slave ship. Setting out from the Caribbean, loaded with takings from the sale of enslaved Africans, the ship was seized by pirates. Their leader, “Black Sam” Bellamy, transferred treasure and guns from ships he’d looted earlier to the *Whydah*, and sailed her north toward the US.

The English naval flag was replaced by the black “Jolly Roger” flag once the pirates were in charge of the ship.

Crew members had to climb up in the rigging to release sails from the horizontal wooden spars, or tie them back up.

Wreck location

The wreck site of the *Whydah* was found just off the Atlantic coast of Cape Cod, Massachusetts. The waters here are shallow and full of sandbanks, making it difficult for ships to navigate safely.

The bowsprit made it possible to add even more sails than those on the three masts, to increase the ship’s speed.

The captain’s cabin at the stern (rear end of the boat) was the most comfortable space on board.

Gunport through which a gun (ship’s cannon) could be fired.

Two large anchors could be lowered from the bow, one on each side.

